Thirty-Five Races, Rated in August

Commit to a Senate map now, and to a number you cannot revise in November

84-355 Democracy's Data

August 2026

01 The question you have to answer before you are allowed to be right

Write down how many Senate seats the Democrats will hold after the November 2026 election. Do it now, before you read any further, and do it in ink.

That instruction is the whole chapter. Everything below exists to make the number you write down more informed than a coin flip, and nothing below will tell you whether it is correct. The answer arrives on 3 November, and by then your guess has to already exist or it does not count.

The reason to insist on this is not suspense. A prediction made after the fact is not a prediction, and the human capacity to remember having believed the thing that happened is close to unlimited. The only defence is a record with a date on it. This chapter builds you one.

> **Before you go on.** Write two numbers on paper, or in a file you will not edit. First: how many of the 100 Senate seats the Democrats will hold in January 2027. Second: how confident you are, as a percentage. Keep them. The second number is the one that will surprise you.

02 The arithmetic that decides what your guesses are worth

35 Senate seats are on the ballot in November 2026, and 34 of the Senate's other 65 are already Democratic. So your 35 answers do not decide the Senate on their own. They are added to a number that is already fixed.

	seats
seats in the Senate	100
Democratic seats now	47

	seats
Republican seats now	53
seats on the ballot in 2026	35
of those, Democratic-held	13
of those, Republican-held	22
Democratic seats not on the ballot	34
Republican seats not on the ballot	31
seats for a Democratic majority	51
of the 35, Democrats must win	17
net Democratic gain required	4

Read the last three rows together. Democrats hold 34 seats that nobody votes on this year. A majority is 51, not 50, because the Vice President breaks ties and the Vice President is a Republican. So Democrats need 17 of the 35 races on your map. They currently hold 13 of those 35 seats, which makes the requirement a net gain of 4.

> Two of the 35 are special elections, in Florida and Ohio, for seats whose regular six-year term does not end until 2028. Marco Rubio and JD Vance both left the Senate in January 2025 for jobs in the executive branch, and both seats were filled by appointment. A chapter that counted only the 33 seats whose terms are actually expiring would leave out Ohio, which is one of the most contested races in the country.

03 Where the data comes from, and what it is for

The 35 races, the people in them, and 12 professional forecasters' current ratings of every one of them all come from a single Wikipedia article, "2026 United States Senate elections". It is read as wikitext rather than as a web page, because the wikitext is where the ratings still exist as words. On the rendered page a rating is a coloured table cell, and a colour cannot be read back out.

Who is in it, and how they got there. Every candidate who has qualified for a 2026 Senate ballot, every senator whose seat is up, and every rating twelve named forecasters have published. The candidates come from state election officials' own filing lists, cited line by line. The ratings come from the forecasters' own pages, each carrying the date it was last changed.

Who it was made for. Nobody in particular, which is the unusual thing about it. The twelve forecasters publish no common file and use no common vocabulary. Cook says "Solid Republican" where Sabato says "Safe Republican"; two of the twelve use a category called "Tilt" that the other ten do not have. This table is the only place they sit side by side, and it exists because volunteers put them there.

What it costs to get. Nothing, and no account. One request to the MediaWiki interface returns the whole article, currently 254,044 characters of it.

What has already been done to it. Three things, and the third is a choice you should argue with. The candidate lists were reduced to the names and party labels. The ratings were pulled out of the templates that draw them. And the five rating words were turned into numbers so they could be averaged, on a scale set out below.

> Wikipedia is not the authority on any of this and is not treated as one here. Every rating in the table is footnoted to the forecaster who published it, and every candidate to a secretary of state. What the article supplies is the assembly, not the facts. The risk that comes with that is real and worth naming: an article edited daily during a campaign is a moving target, so the version read here is kept on disk beside the numbers it produced.

04 Seven words, and the number line they were forced onto

Forecasters do not publish probabilities. They publish one of five words, and the word is a category rather than a measurement:

Category	Score	Meaning
Safe D	3	the other side is not going to win this
Likely D	2	a significant advantage, but not a certainty
Lean D	1	a slight advantage
Toss-up	0	no advantage either way
Lean R	-1	a slight advantage
Likely R	-2	a significant advantage, but not a certainty
Safe R	-3	the other side is not going to win this

Averaging words is impossible, so this chapter turned them into the numbers in the middle column: positive for the Democrat, symmetric around a toss-up. Two of the twelve forecasters also use "Tilt", a category weaker than "Lean", and it is scored at half a point.

Nothing makes those gaps equal. Saying that "Likely" is exactly twice "Lean" is an assumption, not a finding, and a different set of numbers would produce a different average. The scale is printed here so you can disagree with it. That is the honest position for any scale that turns words into arithmetic, and most published averages of expert ratings do not print theirs.

There is a second problem with the scale, and it is worse. It has seven squares, all of which assume a Democrat is running against a Republican. In 3 of the 35 races, no Democrat filed at all: ID, NE, SD.

	on the ballot
Idaho	Todd Achilles (Independent); Natalie Fleming (Independent); Matt Loesby (Libertarian); Jim Risch (Republican)
Nebraska	Mike Marvin (Legal Marijuana Now); Dan Osborn (Independent); Pete Ricketts (Republican)

	on the ballot
South Dakota	Brian Bengs (Independent); Mike Rounds (Republican)

Nebraska is the one to look at. Dan Osborn is an independent who took Republicans to within a few points in 2024, running with no Democrat on the ballot against him. A scale that runs from Safe D to Safe R cannot say what a strong independent looks like. You will still have to rate Nebraska, and whatever you put there will be wrong in a way the map cannot show.

05 Now rate all thirty-five

Figure 1 is the instrument. Pick a rating from the row of buttons, then click states to paint them. The running total at the top adds your calls to the 34 Democratic seats that are not on the ballot. It is always a prediction about the whole Senate, not about the part you can see.

Two buttons fill the map for you: one from the result of each seat's last election, one from the twelve forecasters' average. **Use them second, not first.** Starting from someone else's map and adjusting is a different act from building your own, and it will pull your answer toward theirs. If you want to know what you think, paint the map before you look at either.

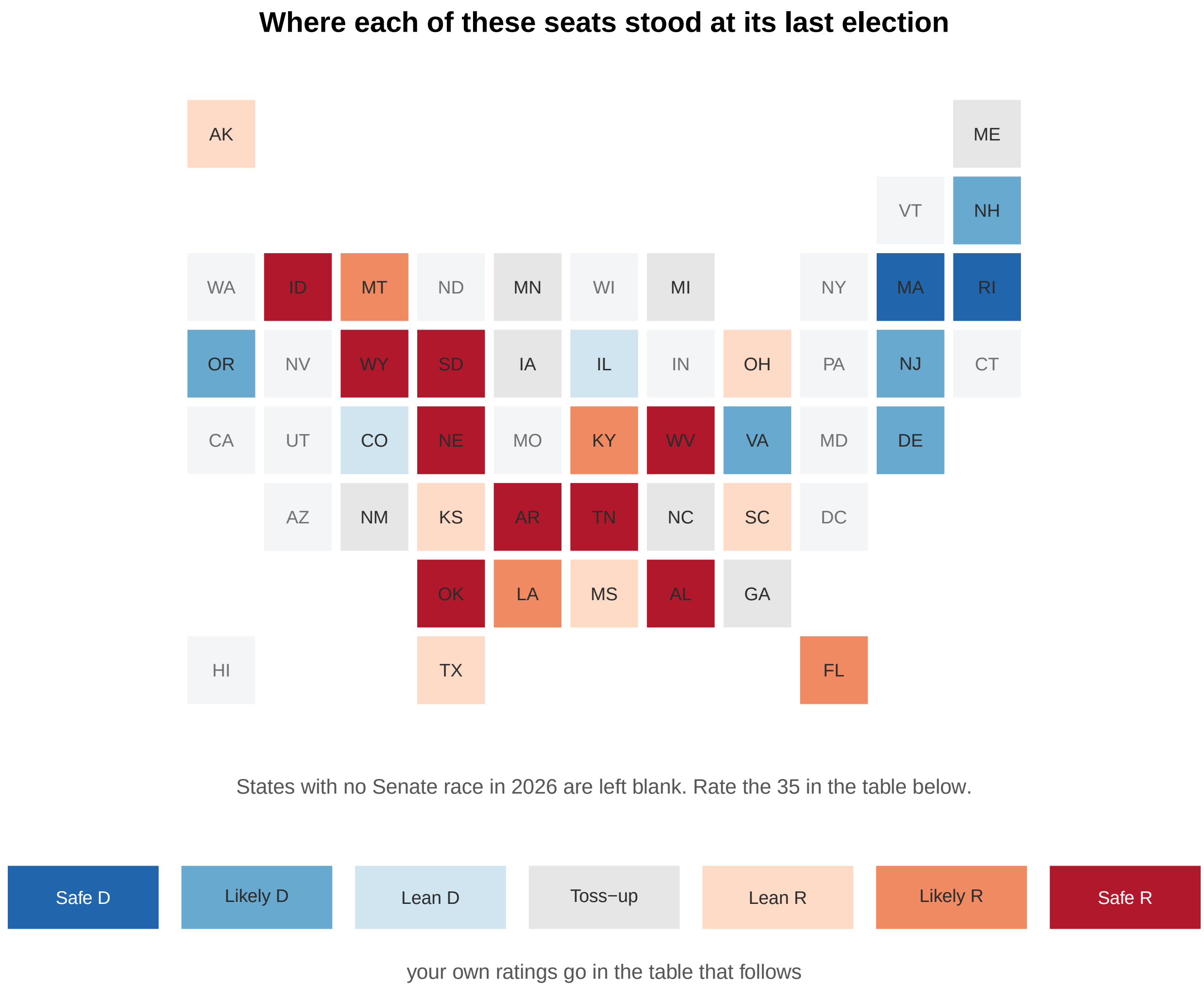

Figure 1. Your map. One square per state, all the same size, because every state elects two senators no matter how many people live in it. The running total above the map adds your 35 calls to the 34 Democratic seats that are not on the ballot. A toss-up is counted as neither, which is why the total is often a range.

	state	seat held by	sitting senator	Democrat	Republican	your rating
AK	Alaska	Republican	Dan Sullivan (running)	David Leslie	Gerald Heikes	
AL	Alabama	Republican	Tommy Tuberville (retiring)	Everett Wess	Barry Moore	
AR	Arkansas	Republican	Tom Cotton (running)	Hallie Shoffner	Tom Cotton	
CO	Colorado	Democratic	John Hickenlooper (running)	John Hickenlooper	Mark Baisley	
DE	Delaware	Democratic	Chris Coons (running)	Jeff Appelhans	Michael Katz	
FL	Florida	Republican	Ashley Moody (appointed)	Angie Nixon	Ashley Moody	
GA	Georgia	Democratic	Jon Ossoff (running)	Jon Ossoff	Mike Collins	
IA	Iowa	Republican	Joni Ernst (retiring)	Josh Turek	Ashley Hinson	
ID	Idaho	Republican	Jim Risch (running)	—	Jim Risch	
IL	Illinois	Democratic	Dick Durbin (retiring)	Juliana Stratton	Don Tracy	
KS	Kansas	Republican	Roger Marshall (running)	Adam Hamilton	Roger Marshall	

	state	seat held by	sitting senator	Democrat	Republican	your rating
KY	Kentucky	Republican	Mitch McConnell (retiring)	Charles Booker	Andy Barr	
LA	Louisiana	Republican	Bill Cassidy (lost renomination)	Jamie Davis	Julia Letlow	
MA	Massachusetts	Democratic	Ed Markey (running)	Ed Markey	John Deaton	
ME	Maine	Republican	Susan Collins (running)	Troy Jackson	Susan Collins	
MI	Michigan	Democratic	Gary Peters (retiring)	Abdul El-Sayed	Mike Rogers	
MN	Minnesota	Democratic	Tina Smith (retiring)	Peggy Flanagan	Michele Tafoya	
MS	Mississippi	Republican	Cindy Hyde-Smith (running)	Scott Colom	Cindy Hyde-Smith	
MT	Montana	Republican	Steve Daines (retiring)	Alani Bankhead	Kurt Alme	
NC	North Carolina	Republican	Thom Tillis (retiring)	Roy Cooper	Michael Whatley	
NE	Nebraska	Republican	Pete Ricketts (running)	—	Pete Ricketts	
NH	New Hampshire	Democratic	Jeanne Shaheen (retiring)	Karishma Manzur	Scott Brown	
NJ	New Jersey	Democratic	Cory Booker (running)	Cory Booker	Justin Murphy	
NM	New Mexico	Democratic	Ben Ray Luján (running)	Ben Ray Luján	Larry Marker	
OH	Ohio	Republican	Jon Husted (appointed)	Sherrod Brown	Jon Husted	
OK	Oklahoma	Republican	Alan S. Armstrong (appointed)	Jim Priest	Kevin Hern	
OR	Oregon	Democratic	Jeff Merkley (running)	Jeff Merkley	David Brock Smith	
RI	Rhode Island	Democratic	Jack Reed (running)	Connor Burbridge	Raymond McKay	
SC	South Carolina	Republican	Darline Graham (appointed)	Annie Andrews	Darline Graham	
SD	South Dakota	Republican	Mike Rounds (running)	—	Mike Rounds	
TN	Tennessee	Republican	Bill Hagerty (running)	Marquita Bradshaw	Bill Hagerty	
TX	Texas	Republican	John Cornyn (lost renomination)	James Talarico	Ken Paxton	
VA	Virginia	Democratic	Mark Warner (running)	Mark Warner	Bert Mizusawa	
WV	West Virginia	Republican	Shelley Moore Capito (running)	Rachel Fetty Anderson	Shelley Moore Capito	
WY	Wyoming	Republican	Cynthia Lummis (retiring)	James W. Byrd	Harriet Hageman	

Table 1. The 35 races, in the order the code reads them. This is the paper version of Figure 1, and it is the one to use if you are reading this as an attachment. Fill the last column, then read your ratings down the column to get your code: 1 for Safe D through 7 for Safe R.

> The incumbent is not the ballot. 10 of these senators are retiring, 2 lost their own party's primary, and 4 hold seats they were appointed to rather than elected to. Only 19 of the 35 races have the sitting senator running for the seat again. Rating a race by how the incumbent has done before is, in most of these, rating somebody who is not running.

06 Submit it, so the class has an average

Your code is 35 digits long and it is the whole of your answer. Paste it into the class form, which asks for two things: the code, and your name. Nothing else.

The form feeds a spreadsheet. That spreadsheet is what the second map on this page reads, and until people submit, the map has nothing to average. A class average is not a better forecast than yours. There is no reason a room's mean should beat a room's best guess. But it is a different object, and the gap between it and your map is the most interesting thing on this page.

> This copy was built before any codes were submitted, so Figure 2 opens on the last-election map instead. Codes pasted into the box under Figure 2 are averaged in the browser, without rebuilding anything, which is how the class map works in the room on the day.

07 What everyone else has already committed to

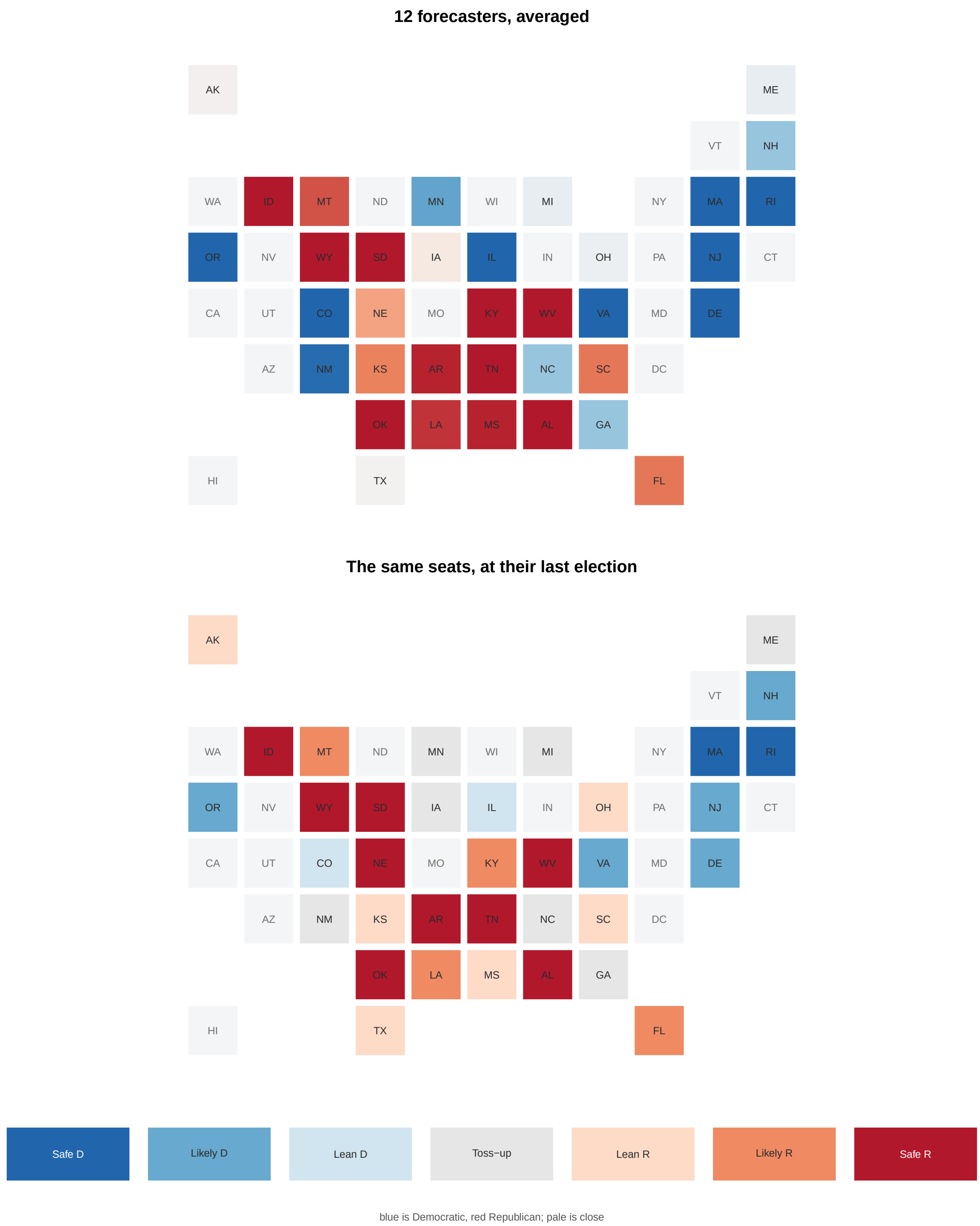

Figure 2. The same 35 squares, four ways. Your map, the 12 forecasters averaged, each seat's last election, and the class's average once codes exist. Nothing here is a result.

Three of the four layers are somebody's opinion and the fourth is a different election.

Read the forecaster layer first, and read the total it implies rather than the colours. Averaged across all 12, the ratings call 16 of the 35 races for the Democrats. Added to the 34 seats not on the ballot, that is **50 Democratic seats**. One short of the majority, in a chamber where 50-50 leaves the Republicans in charge because the Vice President breaks ties.

That is the sharpest thing on this page and it is worth sitting with. The consensus of 12 professional forecasters, in late August, does not resolve the question. It lands on the one number that resolves nothing.

08 Where the professionals disagree with each other

On 16 of the 35 races all 12 forecasters give the same answer. The interesting races are the other 19.

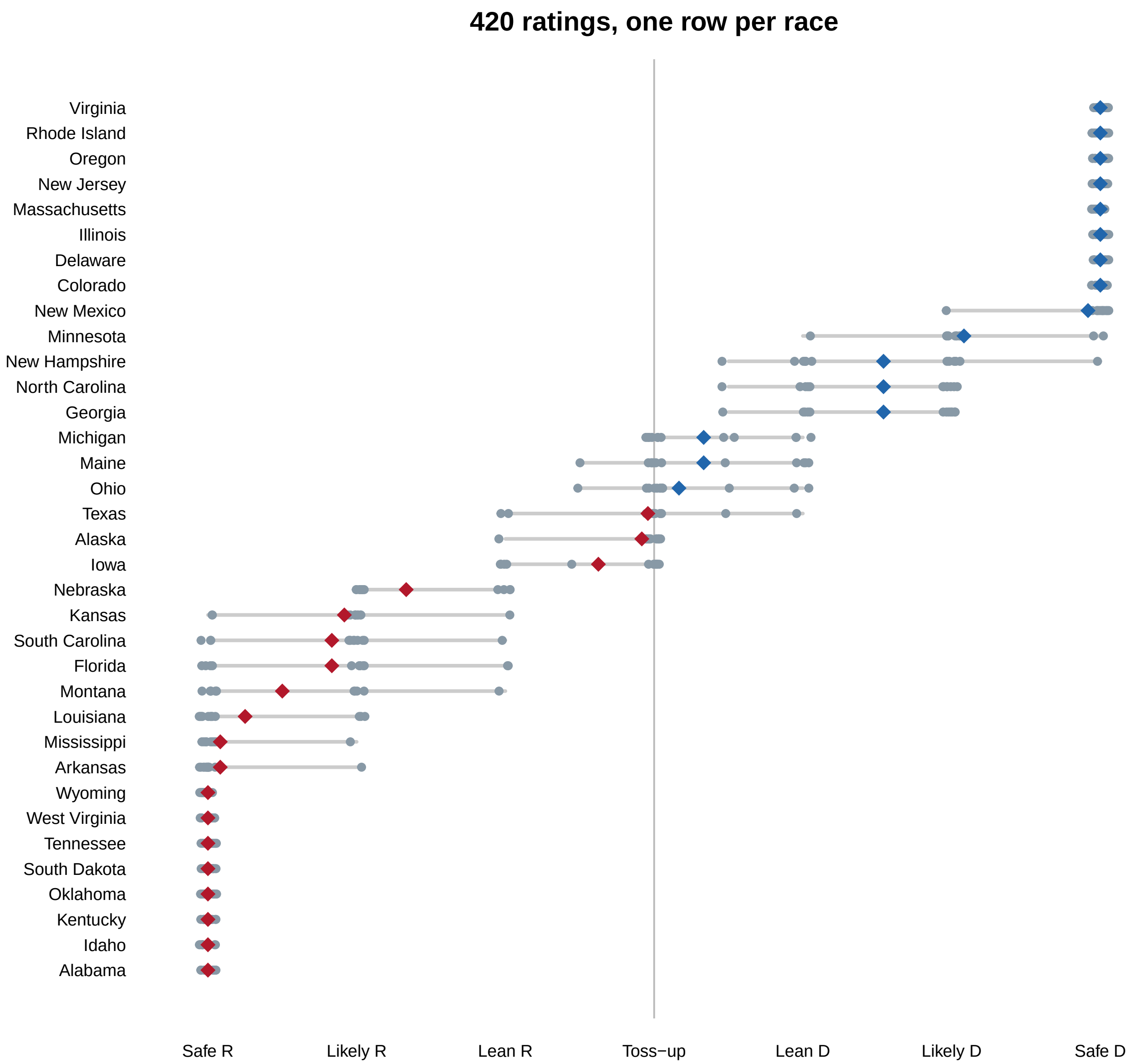

Figure 3. Every rating, one row per race. Grey dots are the 12 forecasters; the diamond is their average. A row where the dots sit on top of each other is a race nobody argues about. A row where they spread out is a race where the professionals do not agree, which is not the same thing as a close race.

Two rows are worth finding by hand. **Texas** has the average nearest to dead even, at -0.04. That is a race the twelve collectively cannot call. **New Hampshire** has the widest spread: its ratings run from 0.5 to 3 on this scale, which is the difference between a race that tilts one way and a race that is over.

Those are different kinds of uncertainty and it is worth separating them. A toss-up everyone agrees is a toss-up is a statement about the race. A race where half the forecasters say one thing and half say another is a statement about the forecasters.

The 12 are not equally far from each other, either. The last column below is how far each one's ratings sit, on average, from the mean of the other eleven.

forecaster	ratings last changed	races rated	average distance from the other eleven
The Economist	2026-08-07	35	0.36
Inside Elections	2026-08-06	35	0.32
Split Ticket	2026-08-11	35	0.25
Sabato	2026-08-19	35	0.23
RealClearPolitics	2026-08-14	35	0.22
Silver Bulletin	2026-08-21	35	0.21
VoteHub	2026-08-06	35	0.21
Cook	2026-08-20	35	0.19
Fox News	2026-08-18	35	0.19
FiftyPlusOne	2026-08-11	35	0.19
Race to the WH	2026-08-22	35	0.19
Decision Desk HQ	2026-08-05	35	0.16

Table 2. The 12. The Economist sits furthest from the rest, at 0.36 on a scale whose whole width is six. Decision Desk HQ sits closest. Neither of those facts says anything about who is right, and it would be a mistake to read the second as a recommendation. A forecaster who agrees with everyone else adds nothing to an average; a forecaster who disagrees adds the only thing an average has to work with.

The dates matter too. These ratings were published between 2026-08-05 and 2026-08-22, which is a spread of more than two weeks in a campaign where two races moved category during it. Some of the twelve are answering a slightly older question than the others.

09 What a rating cannot do, and what your sheet can

A rating is not a probability. "Lean D" does not mean 65%, or any other number, and no forecaster on this page publishes what it does mean. That is why the scale here had to be invented before anything could be averaged, and it is why the average is a summary of language rather than a measurement of chance.

This matters for how you will grade yourself in November. If you called a race Safe D and it went Republican, you were wrong in a way you cannot argue with. If you called it Lean R and it went Democratic by a point, you were arguably right about the shape and wrong about the outcome. No rule on this page settles which. **Decide now how you will score yourself, while you still have no idea what happened.** That is the second half of the exercise and it is the half people skip.

> A useful rule, and one you may reject: count a race as correctly called if you put it on the side that won, count a toss-up as half credit either way, and count Safe as double weight in both directions. Write down whatever rule you choose, next to your ratings, and date it.

10 What this chapter cannot tell you

Whether any of these ratings are any good. Twelve forecasters agreeing is not evidence. They read the same polls, the same fundraising reports and each other, so their agreement is close to one opinion counted twelve times. The spread in Figure 3 is a lower bound on the real uncertainty, not a measure of it.

What the polls say. Deliberately. There is no polling in this chapter, and the ratings that are here have polling baked into them without saying how much. A rating is a judgement that has already digested the evidence, and you cannot take it apart again from the outside.

Whether the candidates on Table 1 will be the candidates. The list was current when the article was read. Maine's Democratic nominee in this file is the party's second choice, after the first left the race in August. Nothing stops that happening again between now and November in any of the 35 races.

What happens in the House. The Senate is 35 decisions and the House is 435. They are not independent, because a national swing moves both, and a chapter about one of them cannot tell you about the other. The seat-forecast chapter takes up that problem directly.

Whether 3 races have been rated honestly at all. Idaho, Nebraska and South Dakota have no Democrat on the ballot, and in two of them the challenger is an independent. Every forecaster on this page still put those races on a Democrat-versus-Republican scale, and so did you, because the instrument gave you nowhere else to put them.

11 Sources

Data

- Wikipedia, "2026 United States Senate elections" (https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/2026_United_States_Senate_elections), fetched as wikitext through the MediaWiki API. Two tables are read: the *Predictions* table, for each race's Cook Partisan Voting Index, incumbent, last result and twelve forecasters' ratings; and the *Race summary* tables, for the qualified candidates. The version read is kept beside the numbers it produced, because the article is edited daily during a campaign.
- The 12 forecasters whose ratings that table collects, each cited there to its own page and carrying the date its ratings were last changed: Cook (20 August 2026), Decision Desk HQ (5 August 2026), FiftyPlusOne (11 August 2026), Fox News (18 August 2026), Inside Elections (6 August 2026), Race to the WH (22 August 2026), RealClearPolitics (14 August 2026), Sabato (19 August 2026), Silver Bulletin (21 August 2026), Split Ticket (11 August 2026), The Economist (7 August 2026), VoteHub (6 August 2026). Their published ratings are recorded here, not recomputed.
- `@unitedstates/congress-legislators`, `legislators-current.csv` (https://unitedstates.github.io/congress-legislators/legislators-current.csv), maintained from the Senate's own records. It is used only as a check: the 33 non-special races must be exactly the states with a Class 2 senator, and the two special-election seats must not be Class 2. If those two tests fail, the parse of the Wikipedia table is wrong.

The data itself

Every figure above is drawn from these tables. They are plain CSV, they open in a spreadsheet, and they are yours to take further.

`class_ratings.csv`, `forecasters.csv`, `races.csv`, `ratings_long.csv`, `seat_math.csv`

Your turn

None of these is answered above, and every one can be answered from the tables you just opened.

- `ratings_long.csv` has every forecaster's rating of every race, scored. Find the races they disagree about most. Are those the closest races, or just the least covered?
- `forecasters.csv` gives each one a `mean_gap`. Work out who is boldest and who hedges. Then decide which you would rather read in August.
- `races.csv` carries `pvi` and `last_share` for every seat. Find the races where the ratings depart furthest from the partisan lean. What are the forecasters seeing?
- Commit to your own rating for all the races before November, then work out what your score would be under the same scoring rule. Would you have beaten the forecasters?

The choices this chapter made, which are not in any source

- The seven-point scale, and the numbers behind it. Safe 3, Likely 2, Lean 1, Tilt 0.5, Toss-up 0, signed positive for the Democrat.
- The rule that turns a past election into a rating for Figure 2's last-election layer: a winner's share of 60% or more is Safe, 55 to 60 is Likely, 52 to 55 is Lean, and under 52 is a toss-up. The share is of all votes cast, third parties included, because that is what the source publishes.
- Counting the two independent senators who caucus with the Democrats among the 47. That is how every seat count in the coverage is stated and it is not in any file.

The article this chapter was built around

- Balk, T. "Can Democrats Win Back the Senate? Why Their Chances Are Improving." *The New York Times*, 24 August 2026. It reports the six-state core battlefield (Alaska, Iowa, Maine, Michigan, Ohio and Texas) and the seat arithmetic reproduced above.

Every figure is recomputed from the files named here, and checked against the values asserted in `checks.csv`. The table is printed verbatim.

Check	Expected	Got	Ok
every race carries all twelve ratings	35 races x 12 = 420	420 rating rows	yes
the 33 regular races are exactly the Class 2 seats	identical to congress-legislators	identical	yes
the two special seats are not Class 2	no class-2 seat counted twice	classes 1/3	yes
seats up plus seats not up is the whole Senate	100	100	yes
every seat is held by one of the two parties	35	35	yes
the twelve rating columns are in the published order	each forecaster's header link before the next	in order	yes
every forecaster rated every race	35 each	35 to 35	yes
the rating scale is symmetric	scores sum to zero across the seven categories	0	yes
no forecaster average sits outside the scale	-3 to 3	-3.00 to 3.00	yes
the baseline rule assigns every race a category	35	35	yes
a code decodes to the scale it was encoded from	1234567 round-trips to 3 2 1 0 -1 -2 -3	3 2 1 0 -1 -2 -3	yes
a code of the wrong length is refused	NULL	NULL	yes

REBUILD THIS DATA YOURSELF, WITH AN AI ASSISTANT

```
I want to rebuild a public dataset from its original sources, without
any starting files. Please do the following and show your work — and
know one thing going in: the main source is edited every day during a
campaign, so your copy will be today's version, not the one this book
captured.
THE FIRST SOURCE. Wikipedia's article "2026 United States Senate
elections", fetched as raw wikitext through the MediaWiki API:
https://en.wikipedia.org/w/api.php?action=parse&page=2026_United_States_Senate_elections&prop=wikitext&fo
No account or key is needed.
HOW TO FETCH IT. Ask for the wikitext, not the rendered page. On the
rendered page each forecaster's rating is a coloured table cell, and
the category you want has become a background colour. In the wikitext
```

it is still a template that names the word: {{USRaceRating|Lean|D}}.

Two tables inside the article matter — the one headed "Predictions" and the ones under "Race summary".

THE SECOND SOURCE. The @unitedstates project's roster of sitting members of Congress:

https://unitedstates.github.io/congress-legislators/legislators-current.csv

One CSV, one row per current senator or representative, with party, state and Senate class. No key.

WHAT TO BUILD.

1. One row per 2026 Senate race. There are thirty-five: the thirty-three

Class 2 seats whose terms expire, plus special elections in Florida and Ohio for seats vacated in 2025. For each, record the state, the sitting senator and their party, whether that senator is running, retiring, appointed or lost their primary, the candidates who qualified with their party labels, and the seat's last election result. Four seats are held by appointees and have no last election of their own; the article's footnote gives the seat's, and the last contest named in that footnote is the one to use.

2. One row per forecaster per race, from the Predictions table, with the rating word and the date that forecaster's ratings carry.

3. A signed score for each rating so they can be averaged: Safe or Solid 3, Likely 2, Lean 1, Tilt 0.5, Tossup 0, positive for the Democrat. Say plainly in your output that these numbers are your choice and not the forecasters'.

4. The seat arithmetic: how many of the 100 seats are on the ballot, how many of each party's seats are not, and how many of the thirty-five a party has to win to reach 51.

CHECK YOUR WORK.

- Every race carries the same number of ratings, and the total is 420.
- The thirty-three non-special races are exactly the states with a Class 2 senator in the roster file. If that fails, the parse of the article is wrong, and nothing downstream can be trusted.
- Neither special-election seat is Class 2, or a seat is counted twice.

> – Seats on the ballot plus seats not on the ballot equals 100.
> – Every seat is held by one of the two parties, and thirteen of the thirty-five are Democratic.
> – Three races have no Democrat on the ballot at all. If you get zero, your candidate parser is matching the wrong party label – Minnesota’s Democrats file as the Democratic–Farmer–Labor Party.
> The roster file changes whenever a seat changes hands mid-term, so a count a few rows off there means an appointment or a swearing-in, not a mistake in your work.